

The Neck Reset

Five minutes. No equipment. Real relief.

Why this works

Most chronic neck pain isn't actually a neck problem. It's the chain of muscles around it — the upper trap, the levator scapula, the SCM — that lock down and pull on the neck for hours at a time. This sequence releases that chain.

Before you start

Find a quiet spot where you can sit upright. Take 30 seconds to breathe slowly before the first release. The point is to feel each release land, not to power through it.

Release 1 — The Upper Trap

Sit upright. Reach your right arm over the top of your head and rest your hand on the left side of your skull. Let the weight of your arm pull your head sideways toward your right shoulder. Hold 30 seconds. Switch sides.

Stop if you feel pinching or sharp pain. The right feeling is a long, slow stretch from the base of your skull down to your shoulder blade.

Release 2 — The Levator Scap

Same starting position. Tuck your chin toward your chest, then rotate your head 45 degrees to look down toward your right armpit. Use your right hand to gently pull your head deeper into that diagonal stretch. Hold 30 seconds. Switch sides.

This one usually feels the strongest if you're stuck at a desk for most of the day.

Release 3 — The SCM

Sit upright. Turn your head 45 degrees to the right, then tilt your head back and look up at the ceiling. Place your fingers lightly on the rope-like muscle that's now visible on the left side of your neck. That's the SCM. Slow steady breathing for 30 seconds. Don't press hard — just give the muscle some passive attention. Switch sides.

The breathing piece

Almost everybody skips this, and it's why their stretching doesn't stick. After all three releases, sit upright and breathe: 4 seconds in through the nose, 6 seconds out through the mouth. Five rounds. Your nervous system settles, and the muscles you just released stay released.

When to do it

Once a day if your neck flares regularly. Once every other day for prevention. More than twice a day is usually overkill — the muscles need time between releases.

When to push, when to back off

Push: deep stretch feeling, slight discomfort that fades after 10 seconds, a relieving sensation.

Back off: sharp pain, electric or zinging sensation, headaches that get worse, dizziness.

When to come see me

- The flare hasn't budged after 3+ days of doing this sequence
- Headaches radiating from the base of your skull
- Numbness or tingling in your fingers or arms
- You can't turn your head to one side at all

Hands-on bodywork resolves what self-care can't always reach. Sometimes muscles are locked down so deep they need direct attention. That's what I do.